Phase 5: Coming Home & Being Brave

God brings His people home, helps them rebuild, and makes ordinary people brave "for such a time as this."

At a Glance	
Month	Month 5
Books covered	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (**3 books**)
Bible section(s)	History (books 15–17 of the Bible; books 10–12 of the 12 History books). **This phase completes the History section!**
Big Idea	God keeps His promise to bring His people home, and He gives His people courage, joy and strength to do His work, even when He seems hidden.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"The joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10)
Bonus phrase (all ages)	"...for such a time as this." (Esther 4:14)
Theme color	Brick orange / sandstone (with royal blue for Esther)
Phase symbol / badge	A brick wall with a small gold crown on top (the "Brave Builder" badge)
Running total of books learned	**17 of 66** (Law 5 + History 12 of 12 ✔)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

God's people had to live far away in Babylon for a long time because they kept turning away from Him. But God promised, "I will bring you home." And He did! A priest named Ezra helped them rebuild God's house and learn God's Word. A man named Nehemiah helped them rebuild the city walls. And far away, a brave queen named Esther spoke up to save God's people. God was working the whole time, even when people couldn't see Him.

How this points to Jesus: God kept His people safe and brought them home because He had a plan: the Savior, Jesus, would be born from this family (Zerubbabel, the leader in Ezra, is in Jesus' family tree in Matthew 1:12–13). Nehemiah left a palace to rebuild a broken city; Jesus left heaven to rebuild broken people. Esther risked her life to save her people; Jesus *gave* His life to save us. And Jesus is the one who brings us *home* to God forever (John 14:2–3).

The Books in Easy Words

15. Ezra

- **How to say it:** "EZ-ruh"
- **How to spell it:** Ez-ra, E-Z-R-A (only 4 letters! One of the shortest book names)
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Ezra the priest and scribe (parts are written as "I," in Ezra's own voice, ch. 7–9). In the Hebrew Bible, Ezra and Nehemiah were one book.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** God's people come home from Babylon, rebuild God's temple, and Ezra teaches them God's Word.
- **In one word:** *Rebuild*
- **Key people:** King Cyrus of Persia, Zerubbabel (the leader), Jeshua the priest, the prophets Haggai and Zechariah, King Darius, Ezra
- **Key stories:** Cyrus says, "Go home and rebuild!" (ch. 1); about 50,000 people make the long trip home (ch. 2); the temple foundation is laid: some shout for joy and some cry (ch. 3); enemies stop the work (ch. 4); the prophets cheer the people on, and the temple is finished (ch. 5–6); Ezra comes to teach God's Law (ch. 7); the people pray and fast for a safe journey (ch. 8); the people confess their sins (ch. 9–10)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Zerubbabel, the leader who rebuilt the temple, is Jesus' great-great-(many greats)-grandfather (Matthew 1:12–13). Jesus later said *He* is the true temple, the place where God and people meet (John 2:19–21).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🧱 Stack one fist on top of the other, like laying bricks for the temple. Picture: a temple with scaffolding.

16. Nehemiah

- **How to say it:** "nee-uh-MY-uh"
- **How to spell it:** Ne-he-mi-ah, N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H (4 syllables: "Knee-he-MY-ah")
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Nehemiah (much of it is his own "I" journal). Tradition says Ezra may have put it together.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Nehemiah prays, leaves the king's palace, and leads God's people to rebuild Jerusalem's broken walls in just 52 days, even while enemies make fun of them.
- **In one word:** *Walls*
- **Key people:** Nehemiah (the king's cupbearer), King Artaxerxes, Sanballat and Tobiah (the bullies), Ezra, the Levites
- **Key stories:** Nehemiah hears the walls are broken and prays (ch. 1); a quick prayer before talking to the king (ch. 2:4); a secret night ride to inspect the walls (ch. 2); every family builds a section (ch. 3); enemies mock them: "Even a fox would knock it down!" (ch. 4); half build, half guard, with a tool in one hand and a weapon in the other (ch. 4); "I am doing a great work and cannot come down!" (ch. 6); the wall is finished in 52 days (6:15); Ezra reads God's Law and the people celebrate: "The joy of the LORD is your strength!" (ch. 8); a huge parade on the walls (ch. 12)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Nehemiah gave up comfort to come and rebuild what was broken; Jesus gave up heaven to come and make us new (Philippians 2:6–8). In Nehemiah 8, the people

were sad when they heard God's Law, but were told to celebrate. Jesus brings joy to people who know they've done wrong (Luke 15:7).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🛡️🔨 One hand "hammers," the other hand holds up a shield. Picture: a city wall with a gate.

17. Esther

- **How to say it:** "ES-ter"
- **How to spell it:** Es-ther, E-S-T-H-E-R (the "th" sounds like "t")
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Unknown. Some Jewish tradition says Mordecai or the "Men of the Great Assembly."
- **One-sentence kid summary:** A young Jewish woman named Esther becomes queen of Persia and bravely risks her life to save God's people from a wicked man's plan.
- **In one word:** *Courage*
- **Key people:** King Xerxes (also called Ahasuerus), Queen Vashti, Esther (her Hebrew name was Hadassah), Mordecai (Esther's older cousin who raised her), Haman (the villain)
- **Key stories:** Queen Vashti refuses the king (ch. 1); Esther is chosen as the new queen (ch. 2); Mordecai saves the king's life (ch. 2); Mordecai won't bow to Haman, and Haman plots to destroy all the Jews (ch. 3); "Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?" (ch. 4); Esther goes to the king uninvited, and he holds out his golden scepter (ch. 5); the king can't sleep, and Haman has to honor Mordecai (ch. 6); Esther tells the king about Haman's plan (ch. 7); the Jews are allowed to defend themselves (ch. 8–9); the party of Purim begins (ch. 9)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Esther stood between the king and her people to save them. Jesus stands between God and us (1 Timothy 2:5). Esther said, "If I perish, I perish" (4:16); Jesus didn't just risk death, He died and rose again to save us. God kept the Jewish people alive, so Jesus could be born from them as promised.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 👑🗣️ Put a crown on your head, then cup your hands around your mouth to "speak up." Picture: a golden scepter.

> **Fun fact for kids:** The name "God" never appears in the book of Esther! But God is working on every page: the right person in the right place, a king who couldn't sleep, a plan that flips upside down. We call this **God's hidden hand**.

> **Timeline twist for teachers:** In our Bibles the order is Ezra → Nehemiah → Esther, but the events of Esther actually happened *between* Ezra chapter 6 and Ezra chapter 7. (See the timeline below.)

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

Last month ended with the fall of Jerusalem to Babylon in 586 BC and a promise at the end of 2 Chronicles. This month picks up that thread. In 539 BC, the Persian king **Cyrus** conquered Babylon. In 538 BC he issued a decree allowing exiled peoples, including the Jews, to return home and rebuild their temples (Ezra 1:1–4; compare Isaiah 44:28, written long before, which names Cyrus!). Jeremiah had predicted the exile would last about 70 years (Jeremiah 29:10).

- **Ezra 1–6 (538–516 BC):** About 50,000 people (Ezra 2:64–65: 42,360 plus servants and singers) return under **Zerubbabel** (a descendant of King David) and **Jeshua** the high priest. They rebuild the altar and lay the temple foundation (ch. 3). The older people who had seen Solomon's glorious temple wept, while younger people shouted for joy (3:12–13). Opposition from neighboring peoples stops the work for about 16 years (ch. 4). The prophets **Haggai** and **Zechariah** (Phase 8!) encourage the people to restart (5:1), and King **Darius** confirms Cyrus's decree. The temple is completed in 516/515 BC (6:15).
- **Esther (about 483–473 BC):** Set in Susa, the Persian capital, during the reign of **Xerxes I** (Hebrew: Ahasuerus), many Jews still live across the Persian Empire. Haman, an official, plots genocide against the Jews; Esther, a Jewish orphan who has become queen, intercedes. The feast of **Purim** ("lots," from the *pur* Haman cast to choose the date) still celebrates this deliverance.
- **Ezra 7–10 (458 BC):** Ezra, a priest and scribe, comes with a second group. "Ezra had devoted himself to the study and observance of the Law of the LORD, and to teaching" (Ezra 7:10). He leads the people to confess unfaithfulness, especially marriages to people who worshiped other gods (ch. 9–10).
- **Nehemiah (445–about 430 BC):** Nehemiah, cupbearer (a trusted official who tasted the king's wine) to King **Artaxerxes I**, hears that Jerusalem's walls are still in ruins. A city without walls was unsafe and disgraced. He prays, gets the king's permission, and leads the people to rebuild the walls in 52 days despite opposition from Sanballat, Tobiah and Geshem (6:15). Ezra then reads the Law to the gathered people (ch. 8), who respond with weeping, then joy, then confession and covenant renewal (ch. 9–10). Nehemiah serves as governor and fights for justice for the poor (ch. 5) and faithfulness (ch. 13).

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God keeps His promises**, even after a long wait (70 years!).
2. **Prayer comes first.** Nehemiah prayed for months (ch. 1) and in a split second (2:4). Ezra's group fasted and prayed (Ezra 8:21–23). Esther asked everyone to fast (Esther 4:16).
3. **God's Word brings joy and change** (Nehemiah 8).
4. **God is at work even when He seems hidden** (Esther).
5. **God puts people in the right place for a reason**: "for such a time as this."
6. **Everyone has a part** in God's work (Nehemiah 3: families, goldsmiths, perfume-makers and daughters all built!).

Timeline (put this on the wall)

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586 BC  Jerusalem destroyed (end of 2 Kings / 2 Chronicles)
538 BC  Cyrus's decree: "Go home!" (Ezra 1)
536 BC  Temple foundation laid (Ezra 3)
520 BC  Haggai & Zechariah preach; work restarts (Ezra 5)
516 BC  Temple finished (Ezra 6)
483–473 BC  Esther becomes queen; Haman's plot; Purim (Esther)
458 BC  Ezra arrives in Jerusalem (Ezra 7)
445 BC  Nehemiah rebuilds the walls in 52 days (Nehemiah 1–6)
~430 BC Malachi, the last Old Testament prophet (Phase 8)
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Map notes

- **Babylon** (in modern Iraq) → **Jerusalem**: about 900 miles along the Fertile Crescent route. Ezra's trip took about four months (Ezra 7:8–9).
- **Susa** (also called Shushan, in modern Iran) was the Persian winter capital where Esther lived and where Nehemiah served the king (Nehemiah 1:1).
- The Persian Empire under Xerxes had 127 provinces "from India to Cush" (Esther 1:1), roughly from modern Pakistan to Sudan. Show how huge that is on a world map!

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Haman's plan to kill the Jews	"A mean man named Haman wanted to hurt God's people."	"Haman made a law to destroy all the Jews. Esther helped stop it."	Read Esther 3 as written.	Connect to later antisemitism and the Holocaust; discuss why hatred of a whole people is evil.
Haman's death	"Haman's evil plan came back on him."	"Haman was punished on the same pole he built for Mordecai."	Read Esther 7:9–10.	Discuss justice and the reversal theme (Proverbs 26:27).
How Esther became queen	"The king picked Esther to be queen."	"The king looked for a new queen, and Esther was chosen."	Honestly: young women were brought to the palace, and Esther didn't get much choice. God was with her in a hard situation.	Discuss power, consent and the ancient Persian court. God works through broken situations without approving of them.
Fighting in Esther 9	Skip.	"The Jews were allowed to protect themselves, and they won."	The second law let Jews defend themselves against attackers (8:11).	Discuss self-defense vs. revenge; note they "did not lay their hands on the plunder" (9:10, 15–16).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Ezra 9–10 (sending away foreign wives)	Skip.	Skip, or "the people said sorry to God for not obeying His rules."	"They had married people who worshiped false gods, which God had told them not to do."	See Big Question 3 below.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Why did God's people have to leave home in the first place?"** God warned them for many years to stop worshiping idols and treating people badly. They wouldn't listen, so God let Babylon take them away. But He never stopped loving them, and He brought them back.
- **"Why did old people cry when the temple foundation was laid?"** They remembered how big and beautiful Solomon's temple had been, and this one looked smaller (Ezra 3:12; Haggai 2:3). Some cried for sadness, and some for joy. Both were loud!
- **"Why didn't Mordecai just bow to Haman?"** The Bible doesn't say exactly. Many think it was because Haman wanted honor that only belongs to God, or because Haman came from an old enemy people of Israel (the Agagites; compare 1 Samuel 15). Mordecai would not give in, even when it was dangerous.
- **"Why couldn't Esther just go talk to her husband?"** Persian law said anyone who went to the king without being called could be killed, unless the king held out his gold scepter (Esther 4:11). Esther hadn't been called for 30 days.
- **"Where is God in Esther if His name isn't there?"** Look for the "coincidences": Esther became queen at just the right time, Mordecai heard about the plot, the king couldn't sleep on just the right night. That's God's hidden hand.
- **"What's Purim?"** A Jewish holiday (in February or March) celebrating how God saved His people in Esther's day. People read Esther aloud and make noise every time Haman's name is read!

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Ezra 1; 3; 6:14–16; 7:10	Going Home to Build God's House	God keeps His promises and brings His people home.	SharefaithKids "Ezra"; BibleJourneyTV "Return from exile"; BibleProject "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah"	Wall Builders Relay	Foundation Stone Shout-and-Cry craft
2	Nehemiah 1–2; 4; 6:15; 8:1–12	Pray, Plan, Build!	Pray first; God gives strength and joy to do His work.	SharefaithKids "Nehemiah"; BibleJourneyTV "Nehemiah"; BibleProject "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah"	Build and Guard	Book Wall craft

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
3	Esther 1–4	For Such a Time as This	God puts us in the right place to do the right thing.	SharefaithKids "Esther"; BibleJourneyTV "Esther"; BibleProject "Overview: Esther"	The King's Scepter	Esther's crown & scepter
4	Esther 5–10	God's Hidden Hand	God is working even when we can't see Him.	SharefaithKids "Queen Esther"; BibleJourneyTV "Esther and Haman"; BibleProject theme "Exile"	Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl	Purim noisemaker (gragger)
5 (optional)	Nehemiah 12:27–43	The Wall Party! (Review & Fun Sunday)	Celebrate: all 12 History books complete!	Rewatch favorite	All games + "Who Am I?"	Wall dedication parade & badges

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: Going Home to Build God's House

Scripture: Ezra 1:1–5; 3:10–13; 6:14–16; 7:10

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God kept His promise to bring His people home from Babylon, and that they rebuilt God's temple with joy (and some tears), even when it was hard.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A suitcase or backpack packed with a few items (a toothbrush, a stuffed animal, a Bible, a snack), a "WELCOME HOME" sign.

1. Walk in with the suitcase. "I've been gone for a long, long time... 70 years! What would you pack if you were going home after 70 years?"
2. Pull out the items one by one and talk about them.
3. Hold up the WELCOME HOME sign: "Today God's people finally get to go HOME!"

📖 **Story script**

> Remember how God's people were taken far away to Babylon? They had to live there for a long, long time, about 70 years! Kids grew up and became grandparents. Many people missed home. They sang sad songs and wondered, "Will we ever go back?"
>
> But God had made a promise through the prophet Jeremiah: "After seventy years, I will bring you home." And God *always* keeps His promises.
>
> A new king named **Cyrus** took over Babylon. One day, God stirred Cyrus's heart, and Cyrus made an announcement: "The LORD, the God of heaven, has told me to build a house for Him in

> Jerusalem. Any of God's people may go home and help rebuild it!" He even gave them back the gold and silver cups and bowls that Babylon had taken from God's temple!
>
> So about 50,000 people packed up and made the long journey home, led by a man named **Zerubbabel**. When they got there, Jerusalem was a mess: broken stones, burned wood and weeds everywhere. But they got to work!
>
> First they built an altar to worship God. Then they laid the **foundation**, the bottom part, of a new temple. When it was done, the priests blew trumpets and everyone sang, "God is good! His love lasts forever!" Lots of people shouted for joy. But some of the old people cried. They remembered how beautiful the first temple had been. The shouting and crying were so loud, people could hear it far away!
>
> Then trouble came. Enemies didn't want the temple built. They wrote letters to the king and scared the workers, and the work stopped for a long time. But God sent two prophets, **Haggai** and **Zechariah**, who said, "Get back to work! God is with you!" And they did. Finally the temple was finished, and the people had a big party.
>
> Years later, a man named **Ezra** came to Jerusalem. Ezra loved God's Word. He studied it, he obeyed it, and he taught it to everyone. God wants us to do the same: read it, live it, and share it!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Practice the "shout and cry" moment. Half the class shouts "Hooray!" and half pretends to cry "Boo-hoo!" Then everyone together: "God is good!"
- **Explorers:** Have kids find Ezra in their Bibles (right after 2 Chronicles). Read the last verse of 2 Chronicles and the first verse of Ezra side by side: they're almost the same!
- **Trailblazers:** Read Isaiah 44:28, which names Cyrus more than a century before he became king. Discuss God's control of history.
- **Ambassadors:** Read Ezra 7:10 and discuss the order: *study → do → teach*. Which one do they tend to skip? Have them plan how to "teach" a Little Lamb something from God's Word this month.

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Where did God's people go home to? (Jerusalem) 2) What did they build? (God's house / temple) 3) Does God keep His promises? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* 1) How long were God's people away? (About 70 years) 2) Why did some people cry when the foundation was laid? 3) What did Ezra love to do?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why did the work on the temple stop? 2) What got it started again? 3) Have you ever started something for God and then quit? What helps you keep going?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How is it possible that a pagan king (Cyrus) carried out God's plan? (Proverbs 21:1) 2) What's the difference between knowing the Bible and devoting yourself to it (Ezra 7:10)? 3) The old people grieved what was lost while the young celebrated what was new. How can churches honor both?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Ezra" / "rebuilding the temple" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Ezra | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "return from exile" / "Ezra" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ezra | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | Likely title: "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah" (one video covers both books) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ezra+Nehemiah |

Follow-up questions: 1) Who let God's people go home? 2) What did the people build first?

> Preview every video first. Search results change over time, so pick the best clip for your group and time slot.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Wall Builders Relay* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Foundation Stone* craft (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** E-Z-R-A (only 4 letters!). Little Lambs: "E is for Ezra." Learn the first half of the verse: "Do not grieve..." and the meaning of "grieve" (to be very sad).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> Dear God, thank You for always keeping Your promises. Thank You that You bring Your people home. Help me love Your Word like Ezra did. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 2: Pray, Plan, Build!

Scripture: Nehemiah 1:1–4; 2:1–8; 4:1–6, 15–20; 6:15–16; 8:1–12

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Nehemiah prayed first, worked hard, and didn't give up when enemies made fun of him, and that God's Word gives us joy and strength.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* 20–30 empty boxes, paper cups or blocks; one "bully" helper (a teen or teacher, coached beforehand).

1. Ask kids to build a wall across the front of the room.
2. While they build, the "bully" (gently, with a smile) teases: "That's a silly wall! A fox could knock it down!" (Nehemiah 4:3)
3. Ask: "How did that feel? Did you want to quit?" Then: "A man named Nehemiah had people say exactly that! Let's see what he did."

📖 **Story script**

Far away in the palace of the king of Persia worked a man named **Nehemiah**. He was the king's **cupbearer**. That means he tasted the king's drinks to make sure nobody had put poison in them! The king trusted him a lot.

One day, Nehemiah's brother came with bad news: "The walls of Jerusalem are broken down, and the gates have been burned. God's people are in trouble and feel ashamed." In those days, a city without walls wasn't safe. Nehemiah sat down and cried. Then for many days he did something very important: he **prayed**. "God, You promised to bring Your people back. Please help me when I talk to the king."

One day the king asked, "Why are you so sad?" Nehemiah was scared, but he shot up a quick prayer to God, right there! Then he said, "My city is broken. Please let me go rebuild it." And the king said **yes**! He even gave Nehemiah letters and wood for the job.

In Jerusalem, Nehemiah rode around the broken walls at night on his animal to see the damage. Then he told the people, "Let's rebuild the wall!" Everyone got to work: priests, goldsmiths, perfume makers, even daughters. Each family built the part of the wall near their house.

But some bullies, **Sanballat** and **Tobiah**, laughed: "What are those weak people doing? If even a fox climbed on that wall, it would fall down!" Later they planned to attack. Did Nehemiah quit? No! He prayed, and he made a plan: half the people built and half stood guard. The builders worked with a tool in one hand and a weapon nearby. Nehemiah said, "Don't be afraid! Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome!"

The enemies tried to trick Nehemiah into coming down to meet them. He said, "**I am doing a great work, and I can't come down!**" And in just **52 days**, the wall was finished! Even the enemies knew God had helped them.

Then all the people gathered, and Ezra stood on a tall wooden stage and read God's Law from morning until noon. The people cried because they realized they hadn't obeyed God. But Nehemiah said, "Don't be sad today! Go have a feast and share with others. **The joy of the LORD is your strength!**"

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Practice a "quick prayer": "Help me, God!" Have them "build" with big blocks while singing "Build the walls of Jerusalem" (see song). Count to 52 together in tens if possible.
- **Explorers:** Act out the "fox" scene. Teach the response, "I'm doing a great work and can't come down!" and use it whenever someone tries to distract them during class.
- **Trailblazers:** Track Nehemiah's prayers: 1:4–11; 2:4; 4:4–5; 4:9; 6:9; 13:14. What kinds of prayers are they (long, short, for help, for strength)?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss leadership: Nehemiah prayed, researched (night inspection), cast vision, organized, protected, and refused distraction. How could they lead a project at school or church this way?

💬 Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did Nehemiah do first when he heard bad news? (Prayed) 2) What did they build? (A wall) 3) Say the verse: "The joy of the LORD is your strength!"
- *Explorers:* 1) What was Nehemiah's job? (Cupbearer) 2) How many days did it take to build the wall? (52) 3) What did Nehemiah do when people made fun of them?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think Nehemiah prayed for months before talking to the king? 2) What "distractions" try to stop you from doing what God wants? 3) Why did the people cry when Ezra read God's Law, and why were they told to celebrate?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Nehemiah prayed *and* posted guards (4:9). How do faith and practical planning fit together? 2) Nehemiah 3 lists dozens of workers by name. What does that say about how God sees ordinary contributions? 3) What does "the joy of the LORD is your strength" mean? Is it about feeling happy all the time?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Nehemiah" / "Nehemiah builds the wall" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Nehemiah | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Nehemiah" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Nehemiah | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah" (watch the second half, about Nehemiah) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ezra+Nehemiah |

Follow-up questions: 1) How did Nehemiah handle the people who opposed him? 2) What happened when Ezra read the Law?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Build and Guard* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Book Wall* craft (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H using the syllable clap (Ne-he-mi-ah). Learn the whole memory verse with motions: "Do not grieve" (shake head, rub eyes), "for the joy" (big smile, hands up), "of the LORD" (point up), "is your strength!" (flex arms).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, when I'm sad or scared, help me pray first like Nehemiah. Thank You that Your joy makes me strong. Help me not quit doing good things. Amen.

Week 3: For Such a Time as This

Scripture: Esther 2:5–7, 17, 21–23; 3:1–11; 4:1–17

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God placed Esther in the palace at just the right time, and that being brave means doing the right thing even when you're scared.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A puzzle with one piece missing (hide the missing piece in your pocket).

1. Let a small group quickly put the puzzle together (or show a nearly finished one).
2. "Oh no, one piece is missing! Can the puzzle be finished without it?"
3. Pull the piece out of your pocket and snap it in. "Every piece has the right place. Today we'll meet a young woman God put in exactly the right place at exactly the right time."

📖 **Story script**

> While some of God's people had gone home to Jerusalem, many still lived far away in the huge kingdom of Persia. The king, **Xerxes**, lived in a giant palace in the city of Susa.
>
> One day, the king's queen, Vashti, refused to come when he called her, and the king became very angry. He decided to find a new queen. Many young women were brought to the palace. One of them was a Jewish girl named **Esther**. Esther's parents had died, so her older cousin **Mordecai** had raised her like his own daughter. Mordecai told her, "Don't tell anyone you're Jewish yet."
>
> The king liked Esther more than anyone else, so he put the royal crown on her head. Esther became **queen**!
>
> Meanwhile, Mordecai overheard two guards planning to hurt the king. He told Esther, Esther told the king, and the king was saved. Someone wrote it down in the king's record book... and then everyone forgot about it. (Remember that! It's important later.)
>
> Then the king made a proud man named **Haman** the most important leader in the land. Everyone had to bow down to Haman. But Mordecai would not bow. Haman was so angry that he decided to get rid of not just Mordecai but *all* of the Jewish people! He threw dice called "pur" to pick a day, and he tricked the king into signing a law: on that day, all the Jews would be destroyed.
>
> When Mordecai heard, he tore his clothes and cried loudly. He sent a message to Esther: "You must go to the king and beg for your people!"
>
> But Esther was afraid. "Anyone who goes to see the king without being invited can be killed, unless the king holds out his golden scepter. And he hasn't called me for 30 days!"
>
> Mordecai sent back a message: "Don't think you'll be safe just because you live in the palace. If you stay quiet, God will save His people another way. **But who knows? Maybe you became queen for such a time as this.**"
>
> Esther thought about it. Then she said, "Gather all the Jews and fast (go without food) and pray for me for three days. My servants and I will do the same. Then I'll go to the king, even though it's against the law. **And if I die, I die.**"
>
> That's real courage. Being brave doesn't mean you're not scared. It means you trust God and do what's right *even when* you're scared.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Practice "brave voices." Kids stand tall and say, "God helps me be brave!" Let them each wear a crown when they say it.
- **Explorers:** Freeze-frame the story at Mordecai's message. Ask, "What would you do if you were Esther?" Then reveal her answer.
- **Trailblazers:** Discuss: God's name isn't in Esther. List the "coincidences" so far (Esther chosen, Mordecai hears the plot, it's written down). Keep the list going next week.
- **Ambassadors:** Read Esther 4:13–14 slowly. What does "relief and deliverance... will arise from another place" teach about God's sovereignty and our responsibility? Where might *they* be placed "for such a time as this" (school, team, job, friend group)?

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who became queen? (Esther) 2) Who raised Esther? (Mordecai) 3) Who helps us be brave? (God)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why wouldn't Mordecai bow to Haman? 2) Why was Esther scared to go see the king? 3) What did Esther ask everyone to do before she went? (Fast and pray for three days)
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What does "for such a time as this" mean? 2) Is being brave the same as not being scared? 3) When is it hard for you to speak up for someone?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Esther kept her identity secret at first. When is it wise to wait, and when must you speak up? 2) Mordecai says God will save His people even if Esther doesn't act. Then why does her choice matter? 3) Who in your world needs someone to speak up for them?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Esther" / "Queen Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Esther | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Esther | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Esther |

Follow-up questions: 1) What was Haman's evil plan? 2) What did Esther decide to do?

> Preview every video first. Some Esther videos skip how Esther became queen; others show it in more detail. Choose what fits your age group.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *The King's Scepter* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Esther's Crown & Scepter* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** E-S-T-H-E-R. Notice: "Ezra" and "Esther" both start with E! Practice the bonus phrase "for such a time as this" with a clock motion (point to wrist).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, thank You that You put me right where I am for a reason. When I'm scared, help me be brave like Esther and do what is right. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 4: God's Hidden Hand

Scripture: Esther 5:1–8; 6:1–11; 7:1–10; 8:3–8; 9:20–22

Lesson goal: Kids will learn how God turned Haman's evil plan upside down and saved His people, showing that God is always working, even when we can't see Him.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A glove puppet or a hand inside a glove; a sheet or blanket.

1. Hold up an empty glove. "Can this glove move on its own?" (No.)
2. Put your hand inside and make it wave, point and grab. "Now it can! You can't see my hand, but it's there, making everything happen."
3. Cover your arm with the blanket and keep moving the glove. "In Esther, God is like the hand in the glove. You can't see Him, but He's making things happen."

📖 **Story script**

> After three days of fasting and praying, Queen Esther put on her royal robes and walked into the king's hall. Her heart was pounding. The king looked up... and held out his **golden scepter**! Esther was safe! She touched the tip of it.
>
> "What do you want, Queen Esther? I'll give you up to half my kingdom!" Esther said, "Please come to a dinner I've made for you, and bring Haman." At the dinner she said, "Come back tomorrow for another dinner, and then I'll tell you."
>
> Haman left feeling proud, until he saw Mordecai, who still wouldn't bow. Haman was so mad that he had a tall pole built, 75 feet high, to hang Mordecai on.
>
> But that very night, **the king couldn't sleep**. (Was that an accident? No! God's hidden hand!) So the king asked a servant to read him the boring record book. The servant read about how Mordecai had saved the king's life. "What reward did Mordecai get?" asked the king. "Nothing," said the servant.
>
> Just then, Haman walked in, coming to ask the king to get rid of Mordecai. The king asked him, "What should I do for a man I really want to honor?" Haman thought, "He must mean ME!" So he said, "Dress him in the king's robe, put him on the king's horse, and have someone lead him through the city shouting, 'This is what is done for the man the king delights to honor!'"
>
> The king said, "Great idea! Go do all that... for **Mordecai**!" So Haman had to lead Mordecai through the streets, shouting about how great Mordecai was! Haman's plan was turning upside down!
>
> At the second dinner, Esther finally spoke up: "Please, my king, spare my life and my people's lives! Someone has planned to destroy us all." "Who would dare do that?" shouted the king. Esther pointed. "This wicked **Haman**!" The king was furious, and Haman was punished on the very pole he had built for Mordecai.
>
> The king couldn't undo his old law, but he made a new law that let the Jews protect themselves. God's people were saved! They celebrated with food, gifts and gifts for the poor. They called the

> party **Purim**, and Jewish people still celebrate it today.
>
> God's name isn't written in the book of Esther even once. But look at all the ways He was working! And He's working in your life too, even when you can't see Him.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Every time you say "Haman," kids shake a noisemaker or stomp (a Purim tradition!). Every time you say "Esther" or "Mordecai," they cheer "Hooray!"
- **Explorers:** Make an "Upside Down" chart: what Haman planned vs. what really happened (he wanted honor → he honored Mordecai; he built a pole for Mordecai → he was punished on it; he planned destruction for the Jews → they were saved).
- **Trailblazers:** Finish the "coincidences" list from last week (the king can't sleep, the reading falls on Mordecai's deed, Haman walks in at that moment). Discuss providence: God working through ordinary events.
- **Ambassadors:** Compare the reversal in Esther with the cross: what looked like the enemy's victory became God's greatest victory (Colossians 2:15; Genesis 50:20 as a parallel).

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did the king hold out to Esther? (A golden scepter) 2) Who couldn't sleep? (The king) 3) Did God save His people? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* 1) What did Haman think when the king asked about honoring someone? 2) How did Haman's plan turn upside down? 3) What is Purim?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) List three "coincidences" in Esther. Were they really accidents? 2) Why didn't Esther just tell the king at the first dinner? 3) Where have you seen God's "hidden hand" in your life?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How does Esther show both God's sovereignty and human courage at work together? 2) Pride ruined Haman. How does pride show up in teens' lives? 3) Why might God choose to work "hidden" sometimes instead of with obvious miracles?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Queen Esther saves her people" / "Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Queen+Esther | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Esther and Haman" / "Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Esther+and+Haman | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Theme video, likely title: "Exile"; or rewatch "Overview: Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Exile |

Follow-up questions: 1) How was God working even though His name isn't in the book? 2) How did the people celebrate?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Purim noisemaker (gragger)* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Spell all three: E-Z-R-A, N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H, E-S-T-H-E-R. Say all 12 History books in order. Explorers and older: all 17 books.

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, even when I can't see You, You are working. Thank You for taking care of me. Help me trust You and be brave. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): The Wall Party! (Review & Fun Sunday)

Based on Nehemiah 12:27–43, when two big choirs marched on top of the finished wall and "the sound of rejoicing in Jerusalem could be heard far away." Celebrate finishing all 12 History books! Full plan under **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration**.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "Building the Books" (tune: *London Bridge Is Falling Down*)

This song is cumulative: all 17 books from Genesis to Esther. (Our new verse is Verse 3.)

Verse 1: The Law (books 1–5)

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers too, Deuteronomy makes five: Books of Law!

Shout: "FIVE BOOKS OF LAW!" *(five fingers up)*

Verse 2: History, part 1 (books 6–14)

> Joshua, Judges, and then Ruth, Samuel, Samuel, Kings and Kings and Chronicles, Chronicles!

(Hold up 1 finger, then 2 fingers each time Samuel, Kings and Chronicles is sung, for "First" and "Second.")

Verse 3: History, part 2 (books 15–17), NEW!

> Ezra, Nehemiah too, Esther too, Esther too, Twelve books of History, through! Seventeen books!

Shout: "TWELVE BOOKS OF HISTORY... DONE!" *(clap 12 times fast)* **Big finish:** "SEVENTEEN BOOKS! WE KNOW SEVENTEEN!"

Fun bonus verse (story verse, same tune):

> Build the walls of Jerusalem, Jerusalem, Jerusalem, Build the walls of Jerusalem, In fifty-two days!
>
> Esther spoke up to the king, To the king, to the king, Esther spoke up to the king: Such a time as this!

Hand motions for each book

Book	Motion
Genesis	Sunrise hands: palms together like a closed book, open them, sweep arms up like the sun rising
Exodus	Exit walk: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door"
Leviticus	Holy hands: fold hands to pray, then raise them high
Numbers	Count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand (wandering)
Deuteronomy	Two fingers up ("second"), tap head ("remember"), hand on heart
Joshua	March in place with fist-trumpet at mouth ("Walls fall down!")
Judges	Pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle (the cycle)
Ruth	Scoop up pretend grain, then hug yourself (loyal love)
1 & 2 Samuel	1/2 fingers, cup ear (listening)
1 & 2 Kings	1/2 fingers, crown on head
1 & 2 Chronicles	1/2 fingers, unroll a scroll
Ezra	Stack fists like bricks (rebuilding the temple)
Nehemiah	Hammer with one hand, shield up with the other
Esther	Crown on head, then cup hands around mouth (speak up!)

📣 Section Shout

Leader: "Five books of..." Kids: "**LAW!**" Leader: "Twelve books of..." Kids: "**HISTORY!**" Leader: "How many books do we know?" Kids: "**SEVENTEEN!**" Leader: "What's next month?" Kids: "**POETRY!**" (preview of Phase 6)

Cumulative recall drill

1. **Brick by brick:** Each child holds a "brick" (a box or card) labeled with one of the 17 books. Kids line up in order to build a wall across the room. Time it! Can you beat last week's time?
2. **Knock out a brick:** While eyes are closed, the leader removes one "brick." Kids open their eyes and name the missing book.
3. **Echo and motion:** Leader says/does a book; kids echo. Speed up each round.

4. **History split:** Kids name the 12 History books in three groups of four: (Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 Samuel) (2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles) (2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther).
5. **Backwards challenge (Trailblazers/Ambassadors):** Esther to Genesis!

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on Verse 3 with motions and the word "Esther." Celebrate knowing the "E" names: Ezra and Esther.
- **Explorers:** Aim for all 17 with the song. Use the "History split" (groups of four) to break it down.
- **Trailblazers:** All 17 without the song; name the section of each; know how many books are in each section (5 Law, 12 History).
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the song. Learn the actual time order (Ezra 1–6 → Esther → Ezra 7–10 → Nehemiah) and explain it to Trailblazers.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition, first sounds) | Word | First letter | Sound it out | |---|---|---| | Ezra | E | "Eh" like an egg 🥚 | | Esther | E | "Eh," same letter as Ezra! | | Nehemiah | N | "Nnn" like a nose 👃 | | wall | W | "Wuh" like a wagon | | joy | J | "J" like jump! | | king | K | "K" like a kite |

Activity: Hide big letter cards (E, E, N) around the room. Kids find them and "build" a wall by taping them up in order: E (Ezra), N (Nehemiah), E (Esther).

Explorers (book names)

1. Ezra (E-Z-R-A)
2. Nehemiah (N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H)
3. Esther (E-S-T-H-E-R) Bonus: Mordecai, Haman, Persia. Practice writing all 12 History books.

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (plus all 12 History books)
- **exile:** being forced to live away from your home country
- **temple:** God's house in Jerusalem
- **scribe:** a person who copies and teaches God's Law
- **cupbearer:** a trusted helper who tasted the king's drinks
- **scepter:** a rod a king holds to show his power

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 17 book names in order, spelled correctly
- **restoration:** bringing something back to how it should be
- **providence:** God's wise care and control of everything, even ordinary events
- **intercede:** to go to someone with power on behalf of someone else
- **decree:** an official order from a ruler

- **fast / fasting:** going without food for a time to focus on prayer
- **Purim:** the Jewish festival celebrating God's rescue in Esther ("lots")
- **diaspora:** Jewish people living outside the land of Israel (literally "scattering")

Syllable-clap method

- Ez-ra (2 claps) → E-Z-R-A
- Ne-he-mi-ah (4 claps) → N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H
- Es-ther (2 claps) → E-S-T-H-E-R
- Mor-de-cai (3 claps) → M-O-R-D-E-C-A-I
- Ha-man (2 claps) → H-A-M-A-N
- Je-ru-sa-lem (4 claps) → J-E-R-U-S-A-L-E-M

Tip for Nehemiah: "**Nehe**-**MIAH**": "Knee, hey! My, ah!" Or spot the pattern: **N-E-H-E** has two E's after N and H; **M-I-A-H** ends like "Jeremiah" and "Isaiah" (coming in Phase 7)!

"Spell It Out" relay: Wall Edition

1. Teams line up. At the far end of the room are cardboard "bricks" (boxes or cards), each with one letter.
2. Leader calls "Nehemiah!" Runner 1 brings back N, runner 2 brings back E, and so on.
3. Teams stack the letter bricks into a wall in the right order.
4. First team to spell the word correctly and shout "The joy of the LORD is our strength!" wins.
5. *Younger:* Each runner brings one whole book-name card to build the History wall in order. *Older:* Spell all three books back-to-back with one set of letters (you'll need to reuse letters: plan carefully!).

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Ezra	Ezra loved to study and teach God's Word.
Nehemiah	Nehemiah prayed before he spoke to the king.
Esther	Esther bravely went to see the king.
Mordecai	Mordecai raised Esther like a daughter.
Haman	Haman's evil plan turned upside down.
Persia	Esther was queen of Persia.
Jerusalem	The people rebuilt the walls of Jerusalem.
temple	The people rebuilt God's temple.
scepter	The king held out his golden scepter.
wall	The wall was finished in 52 days.
joy	The joy of the LORD is your strength.
courage	Esther showed courage when she was afraid.

Read-aloud practice passage

Readers take turns, one sentence each (simple version based on Nehemiah 8:1–3, 5–6, 10):

> All the people came together in the square by the Water Gate. They asked Ezra to bring out the Book of the Law. Ezra stood on a high wooden stage. He opened the book, and all the people stood up. Ezra praised the LORD, the great God. The people lifted their hands and said, "Amen! Amen!" Ezra read from early morning until noon. The people listened carefully. Then Nehemiah said, "Go and enjoy good food and sweet drinks. Share with people who have nothing. This day is holy to our Lord. Do not be sad, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Which king let God's people go home? (Hint: starts with C)
2. What did the people rebuild in Ezra?
3. What did Nehemiah rebuild?
4. What did Nehemiah do first when he heard bad news?
5. Who became queen of Persia?
6. Who raised Esther?
7. What did the king hold out to Esther so she would be safe?
8. **True or False:** Nehemiah gave up when people made fun of him.
9. **Fill in the blank:** "The joy of the LORD is your _____."
10. **Fill in the blank:** "...for such a time as _____."
11. Who wouldn't bow to Haman?
12. **True or False:** God helped His people even when they couldn't see Him.

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. About how many years were God's people in exile? (Jeremiah 29:10)
14. How many days did it take to rebuild the wall?
15. What was Nehemiah's job in the king's palace?
16. **Who said it?** "I am carrying on a great project and cannot go down."
17. What did the bullies say would knock down the wall?
18. **Which book?** "The joy of the LORD is your strength" is in ___.
19. What did Haman throw to pick a day? (It gave the holiday its name.)
20. What is the name of the Jewish holiday that celebrates Esther's story?
21. **Who said it?** "If I perish, I perish."
22. What happened the night the king couldn't sleep?
23. **True or False:** The name "God" appears many times in the book of Esther.
24. What were the names of the two prophets who encouraged the temple builders?
25. **Which book?** Ezra reads God's Law from a high wooden platform in ___ chapter 8.

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

26. Which prophet named Cyrus over 100 years before Cyrus became king?
27. Who led the first group home and is in Jesus' family tree?
28. **Who said it?** "Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?"
29. What was Esther's Hebrew name?
30. Why did some old men weep when the temple foundation was laid?
31. Name the two main enemies who opposed Nehemiah.
32. What was the Persian capital where Esther lived?
33. **Fill in the blank:** "Ezra had devoted himself to the _____ and _____ of the Law of the LORD, and to _____ its decrees and laws in Israel." (Ezra 7:10)
34. **True or False:** The events of Esther happened after Nehemiah rebuilt the walls.
35. How did the builders in Nehemiah 4 protect themselves while they worked?
36. Which king did Nehemiah serve?
37. Why couldn't the king simply cancel Haman's law?
38. In the Hebrew Bible, which two of this month's books were counted as one book?

Answer Key

1. Cyrus 2. The temple (God's house) 3. The walls of Jerusalem 4. Prayed (and cried and fasted) 5. Esther 6. Mordecai, her cousin 7. His golden scepter 8. False 9. strength 10. this 11. Mordecai 12. True
2. 70 years 14. 52 days (Nehemiah 6:15) 15. Cupbearer 16. Nehemiah (6:3) 17. A fox (4:3) 18. Nehemiah (8:10) 19. The pur (a lot, like dice) 20. Purim 21. Esther (4:16) 22. A servant read the royal records, and the king learned Mordecai had saved his life (ch. 6) 23. False. God's name is never mentioned. 24. Haggai and Zechariah (Ezra 5:1) 25. Nehemiah
3. Isaiah (44:28; 45:1) 27. Zerubbabel (Matthew 1:12–13) 28. Mordecai (Esther 4:14) 29. Hadassah (2:7) 30. They remembered the glory of Solomon's first temple (Ezra 3:12) 31. Sanballat and Tobiah (also Geshem) 32. Susa 33. study, observance, teaching 34. False. Esther (about 483–473 BC) happened before Nehemiah (445 BC). 35. Half worked and half stood guard; builders kept weapons with them (4:16–18) 36. Artaxerxes 37. A law sealed with the king's ring could not be revoked under Persian law (Esther 8:8), so a new law was written to let the Jews defend themselves. 38. Ezra and Nehemiah

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Games

> More game ideas and general rules: see `../00-start-here/game-library.md`.

🎮 1. Wall Builders Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** 17 empty boxes (cereal boxes, shoe boxes) or large plastic cups per team, each labeled with a book name (Genesis → Esther); a start line

- **Setup:** Mix each team's 17 "bricks" in a pile at the far end of the room.
- **How to play:** One runner at a time runs to the pile, finds the next book in order (first Genesis, then Exodus...), brings it back and adds it to the team's wall. Bricks must be stacked or lined up in order.
- **How to win:** First team to build its wall correctly, from Genesis to Esther, and shout "Seventeen books!" wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Use only Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (with pictures) or just build a wall with any blocks while singing. *Ambassadors:* Wall must be built in two layers: Law on the bottom, History on top.
- **Learning goal:** Book order from Genesis to Esther.

🎮 2. Build and Guard (Nehemiah 4)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Soft foam balls ("enemy arrows"), blocks or cups for building, pool noodles or cardboard "shields," pinnies for two teams
- **Setup:** Team A ("Jerusalem") has a building zone in the middle. Half are builders and half are guards with shields. Team B ("Sanballat's crew") stands outside a marked line and throws soft balls *only at the wall*, never at people.
- **How to play:** Builders try to build a wall of cups as tall as possible in 90 seconds while guards block balls with shields. When the leader blows a whistle or trumpet ("When you hear the trumpet, join us there!" Nehemiah 4:20), everyone on Team A must run to the leader and shout the memory verse before returning. Switch roles.
- **How to win:** The team with the tallest standing wall at the end of its round wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teachers are the "enemies" and toss balls gently. *Older:* Each cup must be labeled with a book in order to count.
- **Learning goal:** Teamwork, perseverance, the memory verse, and the story of Nehemiah 4.

🎮 3. The King's Scepter

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** A "golden scepter" (wrapping paper tube covered in gold paper with a ball on top), a "throne" chair
- **Setup:** One player (or teacher) is King Xerxes on the throne at one end. Everyone else is "Esther" at the other end.
- **How to play:** Like "Mother, May I?" Players ask, "King, may I take three steps?" The king says, "Only if you can tell me the book after Ruth!" (or any review question). Correct answer: king holds out the scepter, and the player takes the steps. Wrong answer: player stays (with a hint for next time). Players who reach the throne and touch the tip of the scepter (Esther 5:2) become the next king.
- **How to win:** First to touch the scepter.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Questions like "What did Nehemiah build?" or "Say the verse." *Older:* Spelling questions ("Spell Nehemiah").
- **Learning goal:** Review of books and story facts.

🎮 4. Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Noisemakers (from the craft), a trivia list (see Word Trivia), a scoreboard
- **Setup:** Divide into teams. Explain the Purim tradition: when Haman's name is read, everyone makes noise to "blot out" his name.
- **How to play:** Ask trivia questions. Teams shake their noisemakers to "buzz in." BUT if the leader says "Haman" anywhere in a question, everyone must make noise and shout "Boo!" before the team can answer. Any team that forgets to boo loses its turn.
- **How to win:** Most points after 15–20 questions.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use Easy questions and picture cards; teacher reads. *Older:* Use Hard questions and require the book and chapter.
- **Learning goal:** Story review; learning about Purim.

🎮 5. Trumpet Gather

- **Best for:** All ages (great active game)
- **Supplies:** A kazoo, whistle or toy trumpet; three signs on three walls: "EZRA," "NEHEMIAH," "ESTHER"
- **How to play:** Kids walk around the room "building" (pretend hammering). The leader blows the trumpet and calls out a fact: "Rebuilt the walls!" Kids run to the right book sign (Nehemiah). Other facts: "Golden scepter" (Esther), "Cyrus's decree" (Ezra), "52 days" (Nehemiah), "Temple foundation" (Ezra), "Mordecai" (Esther), "Joy of the LORD is your strength" (Nehemiah).
- **How to win:** Kids at the wrong wall join the "builders' crew" (they help the leader check others next round). Last kids standing win.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use pictures on the walls (temple, wall, crown). *Older:* Add the History books from previous phases on more walls (Samuel, Kings, Chronicles).
- **Learning goal:** Matching facts to books.

🎮 6. Upside-Down Day (Esther reversal game)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers
- **Supplies:** None
- **How to play:** Leader calls out commands, and kids do the *opposite* ("Sit down!" → stand up; "Be quiet!" → cheer; "Frown!" → smile). Whoever does the command instead of the opposite must say one book of the Bible in order to stay in. Between rounds, explain one "reversal" from Esther (Haman wanted honor but had to honor Mordecai; the day planned for destruction became a day of celebration, Esther 9:1).
- **How to win:** Last players still "in." (Players who say a book correctly stay in, so most kids stay in!)
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Play slowly with only 3 commands. *Older:* Speed it up and require books in order.
- **Learning goal:** God turns things around; book order.

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-05-printables.html`

Page 1 (Week 1): "Shout for Joy!"

- **Scene:** A crowd of people around a temple foundation of big stones. Priests in robes blow long trumpets. Children and young people jump and cheer with hands raised; a few older people with gray beards wipe tears. Scaffolding and building tools lie nearby.
- **Caption:** "He is good; his love toward Israel endures forever." (Ezra 3:11)
- **Conversation prompts:** Why were some people crying and some shouting? What makes you want to shout for joy to God?

Page 2 (Week 2): "We Will Build!"

- **Scene:** A tall stone wall of Jerusalem half-built, with workers laying bricks. One worker holds a trowel in one hand and a shield on his arm. Nehemiah stands on the wall pointing and encouraging. Tiny fox peeking from behind a rock (for fun!). A trumpet player stands ready.
- **Caption:** "The joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10)
- **Conversation prompts:** Find the fox! What did the bullies say about it? What is a "great work" God wants you to do?

Page 3 (Week 3): "For Such a Time as This"

- **Scene:** Queen Esther in royal robes and crown, kneeling in prayer in a palace room with tall columns and hanging curtains. Through a window you can see the city of Susa. A large clock or hourglass decorates the corner as a symbol of "time."
- **Caption:** "Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?" (Esther 4:14)
- **Conversation prompts:** How do you think Esther felt? Where has God put you "for such a time as this"?

Page 4 (Week 4): "The Golden Scepter"

- **Scene:** King Xerxes on a big throne holding out a long golden scepter toward Queen Esther, who reaches to touch its tip. Guards stand at the sides. Behind a curtain, a hand-in-glove shape (God's "hidden hand") subtly appears in the pattern of the drapes for older kids to find.
- **Caption:** "God's hidden hand is always working."
- **Conversation prompts:** Can you find the hidden hand in the picture? Where do you think God is working in your life even when you can't see Him?

Page 5 (Book-name page): "The History Wall Is Complete!"

- **Scene:** A big brick wall made of 12 large bricks, each with one History book name in bubble letters: JOSHUA, JUDGES, RUTH, 1 SAMUEL, 2 SAMUEL, 1 KINGS, 2 KINGS, 1 CHRONICLES, 2 CHRONICLES, EZRA, NEHEMIAH, ESTHER. The three newest bricks (Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther) are on top with tiny pictures (temple, trowel, crown). A banner overhead: "12 BOOKS OF HISTORY."
- **Caption:** "17 of 66 books: Law ✔ History ✔"
- **Conversation prompts:** Can you read all 12 bricks in order? Which History book is your favorite story?

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. Foundation Stone (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Gray construction paper "stones" (or real flat rocks), markers, a large poster board labeled "God's House"
- **Steps:**
  1. Each child writes their name and one thing they're thankful God has done on a paper stone.
  2. Glue all the stones together at the bottom of the poster to make a "foundation."
  3. On the top, write "He is good; his love endures forever!" (Ezra 3:11).
  4. As a group, do the "shout and cry" moment: shout "God is good!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Draw a picture instead of writing; teacher writes the name. *Explorers:* Write the 12 History books on 12 foundation stones in order. *Trailblazers/Ambassadors:* Write a promise God kept in their life or in the Bible.
- **What it teaches:** God keeps His promises; worship and thankfulness.

✂️ 2. Book Wall (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Red/brown rectangle paper bricks (about 2" × 4", 17 per child), a long strip of paper (4" × 36") as the base, glue sticks, markers
- **Steps:**
  1. Write one book name on each brick (Genesis → Esther).
  2. Glue the bricks in order to build a wall: 5 Law bricks on the bottom row (a different color), 12 History bricks above.
  3. Draw a gate in the middle and write "The joy of the LORD is your strength!" above the gate.
  4. Bonus: draw a tiny fox at the bottom!
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-printed bricks; they glue and color. Focus on the three new names. *Explorers:* Write names themselves. *Trailblazers:* Add one word for each book's summary. *Ambassadors:* Make an extra-large class version for the classroom wall, to be added to each month.
- **What it teaches:** Book order and sections; Nehemiah's story.

✂️ 3. Esther's Crown & Scepter (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Gold cardstock crowns, paper towel tubes or dowels, gold paper/foil, a styrofoam ball or crumpled foil ball, sticky jewels, glue, tape
- **Steps:**
  1. Decorate a crown. On the band write "For such a time as this."
  2. Wrap the tube in gold paper and attach the foil ball on top to make a scepter.
  3. On a ribbon tied to the scepter, write "God helps me be brave."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Precut and pre-wrapped; they add jewels. *Explorers/Trailblazers:* Write on the crown points places God has put them (school, team, family). *Ambassadors:* Make sets for Little Lambs and act as "kings" for The King's Scepter game.
- **What it teaches:** God places us where He wants us; courage.

✂️ 4. Purim Noisemaker (Gragger) (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Small clean plastic bottles with lids (or two paper plates stapled together), dried beans or rice, tape, stickers, markers, ribbon
- **Steps:**
  1. Fill the bottle or plates with a spoonful of beans.
  2. Seal tightly with tape (hot glue by a teacher for bottles).
  3. Decorate with the words "God saves!" and a crown.
  4. Use it during the story and the Bible Bowl whenever Haman's name is said.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Paper plate version (safer); teacher seals. *Older:* Write the "upside down" reversals around the plate.
- **Safety:** Small beans can be a choking hazard. Seal well and supervise Little Lambs.
- **What it teaches:** Celebrating God's rescue; Purim tradition; God turns evil plans around.

✂️ 5. Nehemiah's "Arrow Prayer" Cards

- **Supplies:** Index cards cut into arrow shapes, markers, a hole punch, a key ring
- **Steps:**
  1. Explain the "arrow prayer": the quick prayer Nehemiah prayed before answering the king (Nehemiah 2:4).
  2. On each arrow, write a short prayer: "Help me, God!" "Give me courage." "Thank You, Jesus!" "Show me what to say." "Make me brave."
  3. Punch holes and put them on a key ring to clip on a backpack.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* One arrow with "Help me, God!" and a picture. *Ambassadors:* Write longer prayers modeled on Nehemiah 1:5–11.
- **What it teaches:** We can pray anywhere, anytime, even quick prayers.

✂️ 6. Booth of Joy (Nehemiah 8:14–17)

- **Supplies:** A table or chairs, a sheet, green paper leaves, tape, paper fruit
- **Steps:**
  1. Explain that after Ezra read the Law, the people built little shelters out of branches to celebrate the Festival of Booths (Tabernacles). It was the happiest they'd been in a long

time (8:17).
2. Build a class "booth" over a table with a sheet and leaves.
3. Kids write or draw things that bring them joy from God on paper fruit and hang them.
4. Read the memory verse inside the booth during snack time.

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Decorate leaves. *Older:* Look up Leviticus 23:42–43 to learn why they built booths (remembering the wilderness journey).
- **What it teaches:** God's Word leads to joy; remembering God's faithfulness.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	ZARE	Book 15; a priest who taught God's Word
2	HAIMEHEN	Book 16; he rebuilt the walls
3	HETRSE	Book 17; a brave queen
4	ACIDORME	Esther's cousin
5	MANHA	The villain
6	SURYC	Persian king who said "Go home!"
7	LAWL	Built in 52 days
8	PELTEM	God's house
9	REPTECS	The king held it out
10	RIMUP	Jewish holiday of celebration
11	YJO	"The ___ of the LORD is your strength"
12	HENGSTRT	"...is your ___"
13	SPAIRE	Esther's kingdom
14	RAPEYR	Nehemiah did this first

Answer key: 1. EZRA 2. NEHEMIAH 3. ESTHER 4. MORDECAI 5. HAMAN 6. CYRUS 7. WALL 8. TEMPLE 9. SCEPTER 10. PURIM 11. JOY 12. STRENGTH 13. PERSIA 14. PRAYER

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: *home, Cyrus, temple, Ezra, prayed, wall, 52, strength, queen, scepter, Haman, hidden*

> After 70 years in Babylon, God kept His promise to bring His people _____. King _____ said they could go back. They rebuilt God's _____. A priest named _____ taught them God's Word. Nehemiah heard that Jerusalem was broken, so he _____. Then he led the people to rebuild the _____ in just _____ days! Ezra read God's Law, and Nehemiah said, "The joy of the LORD is your _____." Far

> away in Persia, Esther became _____. When wicked _____ planned to destroy the Jews, Esther went to the king, and he held out his golden _____. God's name isn't in the book of Esther, but His _____ hand was working all along!

Answer key: home, Cyrus, temple, Ezra, prayed, wall, 52, strength, queen, Haman, scepter, hidden

Match the book to its picture / summary

Book		Picture & summary
1. Ezra		A. 👑 A brave queen speaks up to the king to save her people.
2. Nehemiah		B. 🧱 God's people come home and rebuild God's temple; a priest teaches God's Word.
3. Esther		C. 🛡️🔨 A cupbearer prays and leads the people to rebuild the city walls in 52 days.
4. 2 Chronicles		D. 👂 A boy hears God calling in the night.
5. 1 Samuel		E. 🙏 Solomon's temple, kings of Judah, and Cyrus says "Go home!"

Answer key: 1-B, 2-C, 3-A, 4-E, 5-D

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. Does God keep His promises? (Yes!)
2. What can you do when you're sad or scared? (Pray!)
3. Who helps you be brave? (God)
4. What makes you happy about God?
5. Can God see you even when you can't see Him? (Yes!)

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. What's a promise from God that you're glad He keeps?
2. When people make fun of you for doing what's right, what can you do?
3. What's a "great work" you can do for God this week (at home, at school)?
4. When is a time you had to be brave?
5. How can you help someone who is being treated unfairly, like Esther did?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. Nehemiah prayed both long prayers and quick "arrow prayers." Which kind do you pray more? Why?
2. Why do you think God's Word made the people cry, and then celebrate?
3. Mordecai refused to bow. What are some things Christians today shouldn't "bow down" to?
4. Can you look back and see a time God was working in your life even when you didn't notice?

5. Where has God placed you "for such a time as this"?

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. Esther and Nehemiah both lived and worked in a non-believing government. What can Christians learn from them about being faithful in secular places?
2. Nehemiah faced mockery, threats and distraction. Which of these is hardest for you, and how can you respond?
3. Ezra "devoted himself" to God's Word. What would that look like in your actual weekly schedule?
4. The people grieved over sin and then were told to celebrate (Nehemiah 8:9–10). How do repentance and joy fit together in the Christian life?
5. How does the theme of "coming home" in Ezra–Nehemiah point to what Jesus does for us (Luke 15; John 14:1–3)?

Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"Why is Esther in the Bible if it doesn't mention God?"** *Suggested answer:* Esther shows that God is at work even when He seems absent, in the "coincidences" of daily life. That's true for most of our lives too; we rarely see fire from heaven. The book also shows God's faithfulness to His covenant people, preserving the line through whom Jesus would come. The absence of God's name may be a deliberate literary choice, inviting readers to look for His hand.
2. **"Is there historical evidence for these books?"** *Suggested answer:* Yes, a good amount. The **Cyrus Cylinder** (now in the British Museum) records Cyrus's policy of letting conquered peoples return home and restore their temples, which fits Ezra 1. **Xerxes** (Ahasuerus) is well known from Greek historians like Herodotus, and his palace at Susa has been excavated. Documents found at Elephantine in Egypt mention **Sanballat** as governor of Samaria. Archaeologists have also found remains of walls in Jerusalem that some date to Nehemiah's time. Some scholars connect a Persian-era tablet naming an official called "Marduka" to Mordecai, though that's debated.
3. **"Wasn't it wrong (or racist) for Ezra to tell people to send away foreign wives?"** *Suggested answer:* The issue was not ethnicity but faith. The Old Testament welcomed foreigners who turned to the LORD (Ruth the Moabite and Rahab of Jericho are both in Jesus' family tree!). Ezra 9:1–2 explains that these marriages joined Israel to the "detestable practices" of nations that worshiped other gods, the very thing that had led to exile. It was a painful emergency measure in a specific covenant situation. The New Testament gives different instructions to Christians: believers should marry believers (2 Corinthians 6:14), but a Christian already married to an unbeliever should *not* leave them (1 Corinthians 7:12–14). This passage shows how seriously God's people took faithfulness after the exile.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

The Wall Party plan (last Sunday, 75 minutes; Nehemiah 12:27–43)

Time	What happens
0–10 min	**Wall Dedication Parade:** Divide into two "choirs" (like Nehemiah 12:31, 38). Each choir marches around the room (or outside) in opposite directions on a tape "wall," singing "Building the Books" with motions, and meets in the middle. Shake noisemakers!
10–25 min	**Story Stations:** Four corners: (1) Ezra: build a block temple; (2) Nehemiah: build-and-guard mini challenge; (3) Esther: act out the scepter scene; (4) Purim: retell the "upside down" story. Rotate every 3–4 minutes.
25–35 min	**Favorite Video Rewatch** (kids vote)
35–50 min	**Who Am I?** Kids take turns acting as Cyrus, Zerubbabel, Ezra, Nehemiah, Sanballat, Esther, Mordecai, Haman or King Xerxes. Others guess from clues ("I tasted the king's drinks!"). Then play the **Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl**.
50–60 min	**Wall Builders Relay: Championship Round** (all 17 books)
60–70 min	**Joy Feast & Check-offs:** "Go and enjoy choice food and sweet drinks, and send some to those who have nothing" (Nehemiah 8:10). Serve a snack and pack a few extra snack bags for a local food pantry or for kids who are absent. Teachers do oral check-offs. *(Check allergies.)*
70–75 min	**Passport Stamps, Badges & Prayer**

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

- ☐ Says "History" for this kind of book
- ☐ Names Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther (with motions)
- ☐ Says the short verse: "The joy of the LORD is your strength."
- ☐ Tells one thing: Nehemiah built a wall / Esther was a brave queen

Explorers (ages 7–10)

- ☐ Says all 3 books of this phase in order
- ☐ Spells EZRA, NEHEMIAH and ESTHER correctly
- ☐ Says all 17 books from Genesis to Esther (with the song is OK)
- ☐ Says the memory verse (Nehemiah 8:10)

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

- ☐ Says all 17 books in order without the song
- ☐ Gives a one-sentence summary of Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther

- [ ] Names the two sections so far and how many books are in each (Law 5, History 12)
- [ ] Says the memory verse with reference and explains "for such a time as this"

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

- [ ] Says all 17 books in order and names each section
- [ ] Explains the real time order of events (Ezra 1–6 → Esther → Ezra 7–10 → Nehemiah)
- [ ] Teaches one of the three books to a younger child (name, motion, one story, one way it points to Jesus)
- [ ] Says the memory verse with reference

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the "Coming Home & Being Brave" page. Stamp design: a brick wall with a small crown on top and "EZRA • NEH • ESTHER" around the edge. Add a special **"HISTORY COMPLETE!"** sticker, since kids have now finished two whole sections of the Bible library.

🏅 Badge description: The Brave Builder Badge

A shield-shaped badge in brick orange. In the center, a small stone wall with a gold crown sitting on top. A banner at the bottom reads "17 OF 66 • HISTORY ✔." (Sticker, button or sash patch.)

📜 Certificate wording

> **Brave Builder Certificate** This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 5: Coming Home & Being Brave** at Purpose Church Sunday School. You have learned the books of **Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther** and have completed **all 12 books of History**. You now know **17 of the 66 books** of the Bible! *"Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10)* God has placed you right where you are "for such a time as this." Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy this page and send it home on the first Sunday of the month.*

Dear Parents and Caregivers, This month your child is learning **Phase 5: Coming Home & Being Brave**, the last three History books: **Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther.** We'll see God bring His people home from Babylon, rebuild the temple (Ezra) and the walls of Jerusalem in 52 days (Nehemiah), and use a brave young queen to save her people (Esther). The big idea: **God keeps His promises and gives His people courage and joy, even when He seems hidden.** With this phase, your child completes the entire History section and knows **17 of the 66 books** of the Bible!

📖 **Memory Verse:** "Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "The joy of the LORD is your strength." **Bonus phrase:** "...for such a time as this." (Esther 4:14)

🎵 **Our Song (tune: *London Bridge Is Falling Down*)**

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers too, Deuteronomy makes five: Books of Law! Joshua, Judges, and then Ruth, Samuel, Samuel, Kings and Kings and Chronicles, Chronicles! Ezra, Nehemiah too, Esther too, Esther too, Twelve books of History, through! Seventeen books!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. Nehemiah prayed before he did anything. What is something our family should pray about this week?
2. When is it hard to be brave like Esther? Has anyone in our family had to be brave recently?
3. Where did you see God's "hidden hand" working this week?

🏠 **Family activity: "Hidden Hand Journal"** Put a jar or notebook on the kitchen table. All month, whenever someone notices something good God did ("I found my lost shoe after I prayed," "Grandma's surgery went well," "I made a new friend"), write it down. At the end of the month, read them all together and thank God for His hidden hand.

📺 **Videos to watch at home (search on YouTube; parents, please preview)**

- @SharefaithKids: search "Esther" → https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Esther
- @BibleJourneyTV: search "Nehemiah" → https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Nehemiah
- @bibleproject: "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah" and "Overview: Esther" → https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Esther

Thank you for partnering with us! For more about the program, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md`.